as yet no convincing archaeological evidence to challenge the standard theory that this farming revolution began in the Levant and the so-called Fertile Crescent (Lower Egypt and Mesopotamia) in about 9000 BCE and spread eastwards by way of Iran and Central Asia, reaching South Asia in about 7500 BCE, after which it spread through the river valleys of the Indus and the Punjab and on across the Gangetic plain. There is not a trace of Neolithic farming south of the Vindhyas before about 3000 BCE, which was about the time that domestic rice cultivation became established both in India and China. It seems that the Neolithic Revolution and all the advances that went with it came late to South India.

Robert Caldwell's posting as a missionary to the little village of Idaiyangudi, south of Tirunelveli and just a few miles up the coast from Cape Comorin, was his first. Here he won many converts from among the local Nadars, known to him as 'Shanars', whose hereditary occupation was, in his words, 'that of cultivating and climbing the Palmyra palm, the juice of which they boil into a coarse sugar'. These toddy-collecting Shanars became the subject of Caldwell's first anthropological study, a pamphlet entitled *The Tinnevelly Shanars*, published in 1849. They were the largest of several communities in his area condemned by Brahminical edict to languish among the lowest rungs of the caste ladder, which helped to explain why they also made up the largest numbers of Christian converts. Kanyakumari District, in which Idaiyangudi falls, remains to this day the most Christianised district in Tamil Nadu.